

Cues of Commitment: Integration and Naturalization Support in Taiwan and South Korea

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Abstract

Immigration is one of the most contested issues in politics, with naturalization a core concern. Research shows that citizens are more accepting of immigrants who follow local rules and norms, a principle of civic fairness. Yet it is unclear whether civic fairness fosters incorporation in non-Western democracies shaped by ethno-nationalist legacies. We address this gap with a pre-registered conjoint experiment on attitudes toward immigrant naturalization in South Korea and Taiwan, where immigrant populations are growing. We test whether cues of civic participation increase support for citizenship expansion. They do, but with divergent patterns: in Taiwan, civic participation nullifies identity-based penalties toward culturally distant immigrants, while in South Korea biases persist, particularly against Muslim migrants. Supplementary interviews with South Korean migrants show they view civic participation as a path to inclusion, supporting the survey results. The findings extend civic fairness to new contexts while showing how cultural threat perceptions constrain incorporation.

Keywords: immigration, citizenship, public opinion, experiments, East Asia

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1 Introduction

Immigration is among the most politically polarizing issues in contemporary democracies, structuring partisan divides and fueling broader cultural conflicts (Norris and Inglehart 2019; Sides, Tesler, and Vavreck 2018). Mass migration has made most Western democracies dramatically more ethnically diverse than they were just a generation ago (De Haas, Castle, and Miller 2020). This transition was accompanied by growing tolerance and more open conceptions of national identity, but also by divisive political backlashes (Hooghe and Marks 2018). Attitudes on naturalization lie at the heart of these debates (Bloemraad 2018). Naturalization constitutes both the legal culmination of immigrant incorporation and a public test of national boundaries. Despite the vast literature on immigration attitudes (Hainmueller and Hopkins 2015; Avina et al. 2024; Dancygier and Laitin 2014), public support for extending citizenship is less often studied (Peters, Vink, and Schmeets 2018). Native-born citizens judge immigrants more positively when they demonstrate civic fairness by following local rules and norms (Levy and Wright 2020), but whether this principle extends to support for naturalization remains an open question.

High-income societies in East Asia provide a critical setting to investigate this question. The historically ethno-nationalist nations of South Korea and Taiwan have only recently become recipients of larger-scale immigration (Seol and Skrentny 2009; Chung 2020; Denney and Green 2021; Kao and Liu 2025).¹ Although the shares of foreign-born populations remain low compared to most Western democracies, ultra-low fertility and rising migration have rapidly increased ethnic diversity and sparked new public debates (Clemens 2024). Yet there is little evidence on naturalization support in these early-stage diversifying societies. Moreover, it is not known whether social integration cues – signals of immigrants’ willingness to engage with host societies (Weiss and Tulin 2021; Choi, Poertner, and Sambanis 2022) –

¹By “ethno-nationalist,” we refer not to the objective ethnic composition of a state’s population, but to the historical dominance of a national identity rooted in ethnic homogeneity and cultural unity. This framing applies to cases such as Taiwan, where, despite ethnic and sub-ethnic diversity (including Indigenous peoples and divisions between Mainlanders and native Taiwanese), the dominant national identity historically emphasized Han ethnic nationalism until more inclusive conceptions began to emerge following democratization.

facilitate immigrant incorporation in non-Western contexts. Thus, we ask: what persuades citizens in historically ethno-nationalist democracies such as South Korea and Taiwan to extend citizenship to immigrants?

We address this question through a paired comparison of South Korea and Taiwan. Using population-representative conjoint survey experiments fielded in 2024, we assess whether social integration cues increase support for naturalization and reduce identity-based discrimination. The two societies further provide comparative leverage to examine how naturalization support interacts with ethnic and civic identity types, as well as civic engagement patterns. Both are characterized by a history of an ethnocultural national identity, with diverging identity trajectories since democratization in the 1980s (Zhong 2016), as well as contrasting civil society legacies on immigration (Chung 2020).

Our analysis makes four contributions to the literature on immigrant incorporation and public opinion. First, we demonstrate that social integration cues, such as volunteering or co-hosting civic events, systematically increase support for naturalization in both South Korea and Taiwan, highlighting the relevance of civic fairness mechanisms (Levy and Wright, 2020) beyond the West. Second, we show that responsiveness to civic behavior is moderated by perceived ethnic and cultural distance (Sniderman, Hagendoorn, and Prior 2004; Hopkins 2015; Schlueter and Scheepers, 2010). Cues have the largest effects when immigrants are perceived as culturally proximate, underscoring the interaction between behavioral conformity and cultural affinity in shaping public attitudes.

Third, we demonstrate that the effect of behavioral cues extends beyond self-identified civic nationalists (Pehrson, Brown, and Zagefka 2009; Reeskens and Hooghe, 2010), to more ethnically motivated nationalists. Support for naturalization increases across the population when immigrants demonstrate civic commitment, indicating a broader democratic logic of inclusion grounded in adherence to norms.

Fourth, we provide a comparative test of the civic legacy hypothesis (Chung 2020), contrasting South Korea’s dense pro-immigrant advocacy networks with Taiwan’s comparatively

fragmented civil society organizations. Contrary to expectations rooted in work on associational density and democratic responsiveness (Putnam 1993; Paxton 2002), we find stronger cue effects in Taiwan. This suggests that robust civic legacies do not necessarily amplify responsiveness to integration behavior in public opinion.

By integrating theories of civic fairness, intergroup relations, and civic legacies in a comparative East Asian context, our study expands the empirical and geographic scope of research on immigrant incorporation, while also identifying scope conditions that corroborate or qualify existing findings from Western democracies.

The article proceeds as follows. The next section situates our research within existing scholarship, motivates the case selection, and lays out our theoretical expectations that inform our hypotheses. We then describe the experimental design and present the empirical results. Then, to assess the external validity of our experimental findings, we supplement our analysis with qualitative evidence from migrant interviews in South Korea. The final section concludes with implications for theory and policy, along with limitations and directions for future research.

2 The Politics of Immigration and Naturalization

Immigration and citizenship policy debates increasingly shape political discourse in historically ethno-nationalist nations undergoing rapid demographic change. South Korea and Taiwan exemplify these transformations, having shifted within a generation from emigration societies to significant immigrant-receiving ones, relative to other peers in the region (see Figure 1). From 2010 to 2024, the share of foreign-born residents in Taiwan almost doubled from 2.5 percent to 4.9 percent, making it the most diverse society in East Asia. Over the same period, this share in South Korea rose from 1.2 percent to 3.5 percent, an almost three-fold increase. These demographic changes provide an opportunity to examine immigration attitudes under conditions that Western European societies exhibited in the mid-to-late 20th

century.

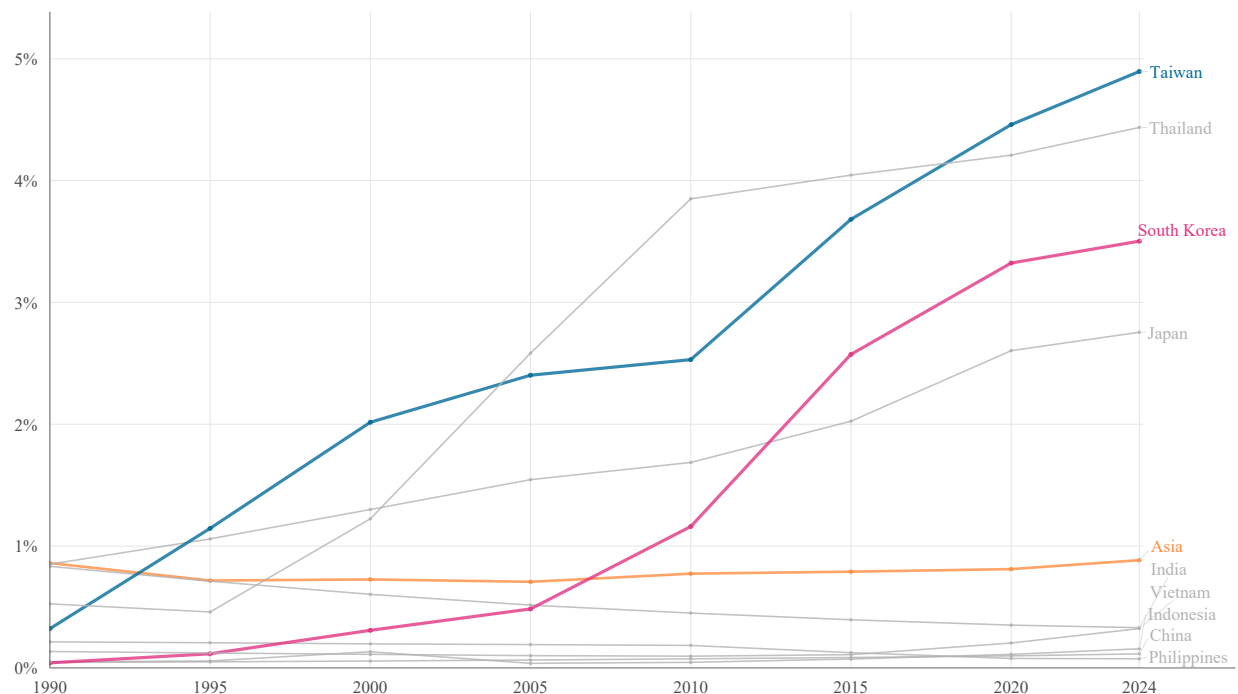


Figure 1: Share of the population that was born in another country

Note: Data comes from the United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs (2024)

Our comparative analysis bridges three strands of research: (1) individual-level predictors of immigration attitudes, including the role of framing and integration cues; (2) public support for immigrant naturalization, a distinct and more politically significant dimension of incorporation; and (3) the macro-historical role of civic legacies and national identity regimes in shaping how such cues are processed. Whereas most research examines attitudes toward immigration admission (e.g., Hainmueller and Hopkins 2015; Bansak, Hainmueller, and Hangartner 2016), we focus on the less studied but normatively salient question of naturalization.

2.1 Integration Cues and the Moderating Role of Cultural Distance and Threats

Research identifies a range of factors shaping immigration attitudes, including economic interests, sociotropic concerns, symbolic threats, cultural distance, and immigrants’ own integration behaviors. Yet the role of integration cues in shaping support for naturalization remains largely unexamined in East Asia, a context with a strong tradition of ethnic nationalism.

Early work emphasized egocentric or self-interest models, which hold that individuals oppose immigration when they anticipate direct economic costs such as wage competition, job displacement, or strain on public services (Scheve and Slaughter 2001; Mayda 2006; Facchini and Mayda 2009). Empirical evidence for these predictions is limited: across settings, personal economic circumstances explain only a modest share of variation, and material self-interest emerges as a weak and inconsistent predictor (Hainmueller and Hiscox 2010).

In response, scholars have increasingly emphasized sociotropic models, which shift attention from personal exposure to perceived national-level outcomes such as fiscal sustainability, unemployment, or the integrity of welfare systems (Hainmueller and Hopkins 2015; Johnson and Rodger 2015; Sobolewska, Galandini, and Lessard-Phillips 2017). These concerns often intersect with cultural predispositions and anxieties about cohesion, value alignment, and national identity (Sniderman, Hagendoorn, and Prior 2004; Sides and Citrin 2007; Hainmueller and Hopkins 2014; Hooghe and Marks 2018). Economic reasoning at the collective level also provides a bridge to symbolic or cultural threat models. Building on this line of work, Kustov (2025) introduces the idea of “altruistic nationalism,” arguing that immigration attitudes are conditional rather than inherently xenophobic: people support immigration when it benefits the broader community and is effectively managed, making institutional trust and collective gain central to recent explanations of public opinion.

Within this broad sociotropic tradition, the integration cues model specifies a concrete mechanism: natives allocate rights and social acceptance based on observable behaviors

that signal immigrants' willingness to conform to shared norms (Levy and Wright 2020). A growing body of experimental research in Germany (Weiss and Tulin 2021; Choi, Poertner, and Sambanis 2022), the Netherlands (Sniderman et al. 2004), Belgium (Baert and Vujić 2016), the United States (Hainmueller and Hopkins 2014), Canada (Donnelly 2021), Western Europe more broadly (Hedegaard and Larsen 2022; Findor et al. 2022), and Slovakia (Findor et al. 2022) shows that cues such as volunteering or civic participation can increase public support for immigrant inclusion.

Evidence on naturalization is rarer. Bansak, Hainmueller, and Hangartner (2016) find that civic behaviors increase support for citizenship, while other studies demonstrate that naturalization itself improves integration outcomes (Hainmueller, Hangartner, and Pietranuono 2017; Peters, Vink, and Schmeets 2018; Choi, Sambanis, and Poertner 2022) and raises fundamental questions about membership rules and civic inclusion (Bloemraad 2018; Goodman and Wright 2020). Despite its theoretical and practical importance, evidence on the effect of integration cues on support for naturalization is limited to a handful of studies in Western Europe (e.g., Bansak, Hainmueller, and Hangartner 2016). By contrast, it remains largely untested in East Asian contexts such as South Korea and Taiwan, where civic membership traditions are comparatively underdeveloped and ethno-national conceptions of belonging remain strong.

At the same time, cultural threat models remind us that immigrants are judged not only by their behavior but also by their perceived cultural distance. Opposition is especially strong when immigrants are seen as violating or failing to assimilate into prevailing values, such as learning the language, adopting local customs, or following dominant religious practices (Kinder and Sears 1981; Citrin, Reingold, and Green 1990a; Sides and Citrin 2007). In East Asia, cultural distance appears particularly salient: while Western studies find penalties for ethnic or religious minority status (Brader, Valentino, and Suhay 2008; Ford 2011), the disadvantages are especially pronounced for groups such as Muslim immigrants in South Korea or Indonesian migrants in Taiwan (Denney and Green 2021; Rich et al., 2022). Inte-

gration cues may therefore matter most in precisely these contexts, as they can mitigate – but not eliminate – the penalties associated with cultural distance.

This study takes up that challenge by testing how integration cues shape support for immigrant naturalization in South Korea and Taiwan. We also advance understanding of how observable behaviors interact with cultural distance in shaping attitudes toward the most consequential stage of immigrant incorporation. Yet cultural distance is only one factor that conditions how cues are received. To fully capture variation in cue effects, we also consider how national identity orientations and civic legacies shape the interpretation of immigrants’ behavior.

2.2 Identity and Institutional Moderators of Integration Cues

Having established that integration cue effects might be moderated by cultural markers, we now turn to additional contextual factors that may condition their impact. In particular, two dimensions are central in South Korea and Taiwan: national identity orientations, which influence how citizens define the boundaries of membership, and civic legacies, which shape the institutional environments through which integration is framed and contested.

National identity types influence immigrant integration (Sniderman, Hagendoorn, and Prior 2004). Scholarship contrasts civic nationalism, which emphasizes legal and institutional adherence, with ethnic nationalism, which privileges descent and ancestry as membership criteria (Brubaker 1992; Kunovich 2009; Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016). Civic nationalists, in theory, should be more responsive to signals of norm adherence, as such cues align with their civic republican understanding of national belonging (Kymlicka, 2001). Stable democratic institutions should encourage a shift from ascriptive to voluntarist and civic forms of nationhood, emphasizing shared civic ideals and participatory inclusion over ethnic or cultural inheritance (Snyder 1993; Nodia 1994; Shulman 2004; Mansfield and Snyder 2005; Banting et al. 2019).

In South Korea, however, the promise of civic nationalism remains tempered by the

persistence of ethno-national legacies. Despite a democratic transition and subsequent consolidation, many citizens continue to believe that (South) Koreans are those born to Korean parents, and skepticism toward the belonging of non-ethnic Koreans remains high (Shin 2006; Seol and Skrentny 2009; Lie 2015; Denney and Green 2021). The tension between an inclusive civic ideal and entrenched ethno-cultural boundaries characterizes Korea’s national identity regime: it is a democracy that formally recognizes diversity more than ever before, yet the normative pull of homogeneity remains powerful.²

Taiwan, by contrast, has experienced a more decisive civic shift since democratization. Education, public discourse, and popular attitudes increasingly emphasize territorial allegiance and democratic values over ethnic ties to Mainland China (Ho 2022; Chu and Lin 2001; Kaeding 2011; Schubert 2004; Wang and Liu 2004; Zhong 2016). In an effort to distance Taiwanese from Chinese identity and maximize voter pools, the multi-ethnic dimension of Taiwanese history was explicitly foregrounded, while sub-ethnic differences between native Taiwanese and post-WWII immigrants from Mainland were gradually deemphasized (Chen et al 2023; Chu and Lin 2001; Simon 2007; Schubert 2004; Wang and Liu, 2004). Recent research on immigrant acceptance suggests that cultural distance plays a role (Rich et al. 2022), but an ethnic premium for Han Chinese is moderate and not extended to immigrants with a Mainland Chinese background (Kao and Liu 2025). Nonetheless, immigrant incorporation remains peripheral to dominant identity narratives, which potentially limits the extent to which civic nationalism is extended to foreign-born residents.

Across both cases, then, the coexistence of civic and ethnic elements raises important questions about whether self-reported civic identity moderates responsiveness to behavioral integration cues – a central focus of the analysis that follows. The coexistence of civic and ethnic elements in South Korea and Taiwan raises important questions about whether

²Hur (2023) shows how South Korea’s civic duty regime rests on a national narrative that tightly binds ethnic nationalism with democratic obligation, a linkage forged in the mid-20th century and reinforced through historical struggles. Yet, as Denney (2025) argues, the same ethno-national attachment that bolsters cohesion also constrains inclusion: without a conscious broadening of the national story, immigration and demographic change may test the limits of civic belonging in the Korean polity.

self-reported civic identity moderates responsiveness to behavioral integration cues.

Chung (2020) argues that civic legacies, define the historical patterns of civic engagement on immigration, condition how societies frame, normatively assess, and institutionalize immigrant inclusion. In South Korea, a civic legacy grounded in labor mobilization and democratization activism has fostered dense civil society networks that advocate for immigrants’ rights. These networks helped institutionalize pro-integration norms through state-supported initiatives like the Multicultural Family Support Centers, which emerged as part of Korea’s development of “state-coordinated multiculturalism” (Chung 2020: 152–155).

Taiwan, by contrast, exhibits a weaker civic legacy in this domain. Its civil society was shaped primarily by democratization struggles and sovereignty and identity vis-à-vis Mainland China. It has not developed a sustained advocacy infrastructure for immigrants. As a result, migrant integration efforts remain fragmented, reactive, and more locally contingent, reflecting what Chung terms a “bottom-up multiculturalism with adjectives”; this is a more diffuse and less institutionalized model of incorporation (Chung 2020: 174–177).

These divergent institutional environments offer theoretical leverage on cue effects. In Korea, society-wide exposure to pro-integration discourse and dense advocacy networks may increase the salience of social integration cues. In Taiwan, weaker civic infrastructure and less consistent elite signaling should dampen cue responsiveness. Our study tests whether such historical trajectories shape how citizens evaluate immigrants’ behavior as signals of social integration.

2.3 Hypotheses

Building on the preceding literature review, we develop four hypotheses. Appendix C of the Supplementary Information provides the pre-registration overview. The first concerns the direct effect of integration cues on naturalization preferences. The next three specify conditions under which these effects are likely to vary: by immigrants’ cultural distance, by respondents’ national identity orientations, and by the civic legacies of Taiwan and South

Korea.

H₁ (Integration Cue Effect). Immigrants who exhibit social integration cues will receive higher support for naturalization than otherwise identical immigrants who do not.

Experimental research suggests that social integration cues, such as volunteering or civic participation, can increase support for immigrant inclusion by signaling commitment to shared norms (Hainmueller and Hopkins 2015; Levy and Wright 2020). Consonant with the civic fairness principle (Levy and Wright 2020) and theories of norm conformity (Choi, Sambanis, and Poertner 2022), we expect both Korean and Taiwanese respondents to reward social integration cues that demonstrate commitment to shared civic values.

H₃ (Cultural Distance Moderation). Integration cues will have a stronger effect on ethnically and culturally distinct immigrants, compared to co-ethnic or origin-proximate immigrants.

Integration cues offer information that can directly counter negative stereotypes and threat perceptions often activated by out-group origins, which otherwise diminish support for inclusion (Hopkins and Hainmueller 2014). Challenging stereotypes can decrease associated penalties (Baert and Vujić 2016; Weiss and Tulin 2021). Thus, these cues will yield larger benefits for profiles with culturally distant ascriptive traits, such as religious minorities or immigrants from regions perceived to lack shared norms, compared to co-ethnic or origin-proximate immigrants, who tend to be viewed more favorably.

H₃ (Civic Nationalist Moderation). Civic nationalists will be more responsive to integration cues compared to ethnic nationalists. This effect will be stronger in South Korea than in Taiwan.

Civic nationalists define national identity by shared values and political participation (Brubaker 1992; Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016), making them more receptive to signs that immigrants adhere to these norms. By contrast, ethnic nationalists define identity based on ancestry or ethnicity and should be less easily persuaded by an immigrant’s compliance with local norms (Kunovich 2009; Sniderman, Hagendoorn, and Prior 2004). Consequently, we anticipate stronger effects from these cues among civic nationalists in both Korea and Taiwan, with potentially greater overall responsiveness in Korea due to its more established civic legacy.

H₄ (Civic Legacy Moderation). Integration cues will have a stronger positive effect on naturalization support in South Korea than in Taiwan.

Korea’s civic-activist legacy has long legitimized migrant advocacy through dense civil society networks and state coordination, while Taiwan’s civic infrastructure has been thinner and less consistently oriented toward immigrant inclusion (Chung 2020). These legacies should condition natives’ interpretation of cues: where immigrants have been consistently presented by civil society as potential members, natives are more likely to focus on norm adherence.

3 Data and Methodology

Our study measures native attitudes toward immigrant naturalization in South Korea and Taiwan using choice-based conjoint survey experiments (Hainmueller, Hopkins, and Yamamoto 2014). We fielded online surveys via Qualtrics between January and June 2024, targeting native-born adult citizens (18+). Respondents were recruited from Qualtrics’ online panel using stratified quota sampling to mirror national census distributions on age, sex, and region. Multiple quality assurance protocols were implemented: Qualtrics’ in-built fraud detection tools, manual attention and manipulation checks, and survey completion validation. Responses failing these criteria were replaced in consultation with the Qualtrics

project manager to ensure data validity. The final samples consist of 2,005 respondents in South Korea and 2,014 in Taiwan. Appendix A of the Supplementary Information provides further detail on the sampling strategy, quality checks, and demographic characteristics.

Each respondent completed a series of tasks. In each task, they were introduced to a hypothetical scenario of the national parliament developing a new naturalization program, and that public input would help guide the policy. Respondents then viewed two immigrant profiles and were asked to select which applicant should be prioritized for citizenship. They also rated each immigrant individually on a 1–7 scale. South Korean respondents completed 10 paired-choice tasks; Taiwanese respondents completed seven. After the seventh task, respondents were prompted to explain their reasoning in open-ended form as part of a manipulation check.

Table 1 summarizes the eleven randomized attributes and levels used to construct profiles. Figure 1 illustrates the design interface as seen by respondents. Three profile attributes are central to the hypotheses:

1. *Social Integration cue*
2. *Ethnicity* (ascriptive identity):
3. *Religion* (cultural identity)

The remaining attributes – country of origin, family status, age, sex, prior work experience, prior trips, years since arrival, and language ability – serve as controls and realism enhancers. All attributes and levels were fully randomized with equal probability across profiles and tasks. Respondents first completed socio-demographic background questions, then proceeded through the evaluative tasks. Randomization checks confirm balance across covariates and countries (see Appendix B).

As an exploratory extension related to H3, we also randomized a civil society framing prime across respondents. This brief introductory statement, shown to half of the respondents before the conjoint tasks, emphasized the role of NGOs, community leaders, and

religious groups in shaping the proposed immigration reform (see Appendix D). While this intervention was designed to test whether elite-led civic messaging amplifies responsiveness to integration cues, we do not observe consistent framing effects and do not foreground these results in our main analysis.

Immigrant profiles were fully randomized within tasks, with each attribute independently shuffled across hypothetical applicants. The social integration cue (our primary treatment) is randomly assigned at the respondent level, following best practices for minimizing interference across conjoint tasks (Kirkland and Coppock 2018). Respondents were either exposed to profiles that included a behavioral integration signal (e.g., "regular volunteer," "co-hosts civic events") or to profiles without this information. Unlike profile-level randomization, which may lead to cue dilution or learning effects, respondent-level assignment ensures clearer identification of average treatment effects. We adopt this design to isolate how exposure to integration signals shapes baseline attitudes across all conjoint evaluations, independent of attribute position or sequencing. In addition, the civil society framing statement, priming respondents to consider either state-led or grassroots-led civic efforts, was randomized at the respondent level. This dual-randomization structure serves distinct purposes. Profile-level randomization enables estimation of the causal effects of applicant traits, while respondent-level randomization of the integration cue allows us to measure how the presence of integration information shapes overall preferences, avoiding exposure effects without risk of within-task contamination (Kirkland and Coppock 2018).

Attribute	Levels	Rationale for Attribute & Levels
Social integration*	Only associates with fellow expatriates Often spends time alone Co-hosts monthly multicultural events in collaboration with local government Volunteers weekly at a local community center with neighbors	The social integration attribute includes levels that range from minimal engagement to active participation in the host community. The levels "only associates with fellow expatriates" and "often spends time alone" represent minimal integration efforts, serving as baselines to assess the impact of more active integration behaviors. "Co-hosts monthly multicultural events in collaboration with local government" and "volunteers weekly at a local community center with neighbors" reflect significant efforts to engage with the host society; these values are used to measure the effect of social integration cues on attitudes and are used for hypotheses 1-4.
Ethnicity*	Co-ethnic Not co-ethnic	Co-ethnic (Korean or Han Chinese) are used to measure ascriptive identity markers to test for co-ethnic effects in immigrant integration and as a moderating variable for hypothesis #2.
Religion*	Not religious Christian Buddhist Muslim	The religion attribute addresses cultural identity and potential biases against religious minorities. These levels help assess how different religious affiliations, particularly those that are minority or associated with specific cultural heritages, affect public attitudes toward immigrant integration. It is used as a moderating variable for hypothesis #2.
Country of origin	United States China Indonesia Brazil [ROK only] South Korea [ROC only] the Philippines	Country of origin includes diverse levels to capture regional and cultural biases.
Family status	Single Married Married with children	Family status is included to understand its impact on perceptions of stability and commitment to the host country.

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Table 1 – *Continued from previous page*

Attribute	Levels	Rationale for Levels
Age	27	The age attribute examines how different life stages influence public attitudes towards immigrants.
	36	
	47	
	58	
Sex	Male	The sex attribute includes "male" as the baseline and "female" to assess potential gender biases.
	Female	
Prior work experience	None	Prior work experience levels provide insight into how previous engagement with the labor market influences public opinion.
	Worked in home country	
	Worked previously in country	
Prior trips to country	Visited once before with friends	This attribute examines the impact of previous visits to the host country on public attitudes.
	Has previously overstayed visa	
	Visited on a short-term working visa	
Years since arrival	2 years	The years since arrival attribute looks at the length of stay and its influence on perceived integration.
	7 years	
	12 years	
Language ability	None	Language ability is a critical factor in integration and could be considered an alternative to the integration cue.
	Broken	
	Conversational	
	Fluent	

Table 1: Attributes Summary

Note: Attributes marked in **bold** with an asterisk (*) denote primary quantity of interest.

	Immigrant A	Immigrant B																
Social integration	Only associates with fellow expatriates	Volunteers weekly at a local community center																
Religion	Christian	Muslim																
Ethnicity	Co-ethnic	Non-co-ethnic																
Country of origin	United States	Indonesia																
Occupation	Unemployed	Agricultural worker																
Age	36	47																
Sex	Male	Female																
Family status	Single	Married with children																
Prior work experience	None	Worked previously in the country																
Prior trips to the country	Has previously overstayed a visa	Visited on a short-term working visa																
Years since arrival	7 years	2 years																
Native language ability	Fluent	Conversational																
Please choose which immigrant you prefer for citizenship. ☐ Immigrant A ☐ Immigrant B Then, rate how much each immigrant should be prioritized for citizenship, on a scale from 1 (not at all) to 7 (definitely). <table style="width: 100%; border-collapse: collapse;"> <tr> <td style="width: 15%;">Immigrant A:</td> <td style="width: 10%; text-align: center;">1</td> <td style="width: 10%; text-align: center;">2</td> <td style="width: 10%; text-align: center;">3</td> <td style="width: 10%; text-align: center;">4</td> <td style="width: 10%; text-align: center;">5</td> <td style="width: 10%; text-align: center;">6</td> <td style="width: 10%; text-align: center;">7</td> </tr> <tr> <td>Immigrant B:</td> <td style="text-align: center;">1</td> <td style="text-align: center;">2</td> <td style="text-align: center;">3</td> <td style="text-align: center;">4</td> <td style="text-align: center;">5</td> <td style="text-align: center;">6</td> <td style="text-align: center;">7</td> </tr> </table>			Immigrant A:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	Immigrant B:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Immigrant A:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7											
Immigrant B:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7											

Figure 2: The experimental design

Note: This is an English-language approximation of the experimental design as viewed by respondents. Respondents evaluated two randomly generated profiles by both choosing which immigrant they preferred for citizenship and rating each on a 1–7 scale of citizenship priority.

Together, this design allows us to test our four hypotheses. For H_1 , we estimate the average marginal component effect (AMCE) of strong integration behavior (volunteering or co-hosting events) relative to a low-information baseline, with standard errors clustered by respondent. To aid interpretation, we also report marginal means. For H_2 , we estimate interaction models between the integration cue and two key ascriptive traits – ethnicity and religion – and present subgroup-specific marginal means following Leeper, Hobolt, and Tilley (2020). H_3 and H_4 leverage variation across countries (Taiwan vs. South Korea) and individual civic orientations to test whether responsiveness to integration cues varies by societal context and identity predispositions.

For H_1 and to a lesser extent H_2 , we supplement the conjoint analysis with qualitative interview data from the Immigrant Incorporation in East Asian Democracies project (Chung et al. 2015), focusing on South Korea. These interviews allow us to examine whether immigrants themselves, who hail from culturally diverse backgrounds, recognize and respond to the same behavioral expectations our experiment suggests natives reward – an observable implication of the “civic fairness” logic embedded in H_1 . Specifically, we assess whether immigrants describe volunteering, participating in civic life, or visibly engaging with community organizations as strategic responses to gain social legitimacy or reduce stigma. Several interviewees report taking up unpaid roles in schools or community centers to be seen as contributing members, mirroring the integration signals tested in the conjoint experiment. This alignment lends credibility to the behavioral mechanism we propose.

H_3 exploits within-country variation in national identity. We classify respondents as civic nationalists if they deem citizenship, language proficiency, and respect for laws essential to being a “true” Korean/Taiwanese and reject ancestry or birthplace as necessary (Kunovich 2009; Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016). Respondents are classified as *civic identifiers* when they rate both citizenship and respect for laws/political institutions as either “very important” or “somewhat important” and simultaneously do not rate shared ancestry and birthplace as any degree of importance. All other respondents are coded as *non-civic*

identifiers. We then estimate integration-cue marginal means separately for civic nationalists and all others. Results are robust to alternative specifications, such as excluding ancestry.

H_4 concerns cross-national moderation by civic legacies. Because our comparison involves only two cases, we treat our country cases as a qualitative moderator in assessing Chung’s (2020) framework. In practice, this means we interpret variation in cue effects between Korea and Taiwan as evidence of how civic legacies condition responsiveness to integration cues. We approach this as a comparative case study, combining historical analysis with embedded survey experiments. This design allows us to link country-level patterns to differences in civil society development, state signaling, and identity pluralism, while maintaining causal leverage through the experimental component.

4 Findings

This section tests the four hypotheses using data from conjoint experiments in South Korea and Taiwan. We first assess the direct effect of behavioral integration cues on support for immigrant naturalization (H_1), then examine whether these cues mitigate identity-based penalties tied to ethnicity and religion (H_2). We next test whether responsiveness varies by national identity orientation (H_3), and finally evaluate whether these patterns differ across the two national contexts (H_4). Results are presented using average marginal component effects (AMCEs) and marginal means, with figures referenced throughout. Full model specifications and ratings-based robustness checks are reported in Appendix D of the SI.

4.1 Main Effects of Integration Cues

Figure 2 shows marginal means and AMCEs for integration cues across both countries. In both contexts, behavioral signals of civic engagement strongly increase support for immigrant naturalization. In Taiwan, the probability of selection rises from approximately 42 percent for low-engagement profiles (“spends time alone”) to over 61 percent for high-engagement

profiles (“volunteers weekly”), a treatment effect of roughly 19 percentage points. In South Korea, support increases from approximately 47 percent to approximately 58 percent, an 11-point increase that, while smaller, remains substantively meaningful.

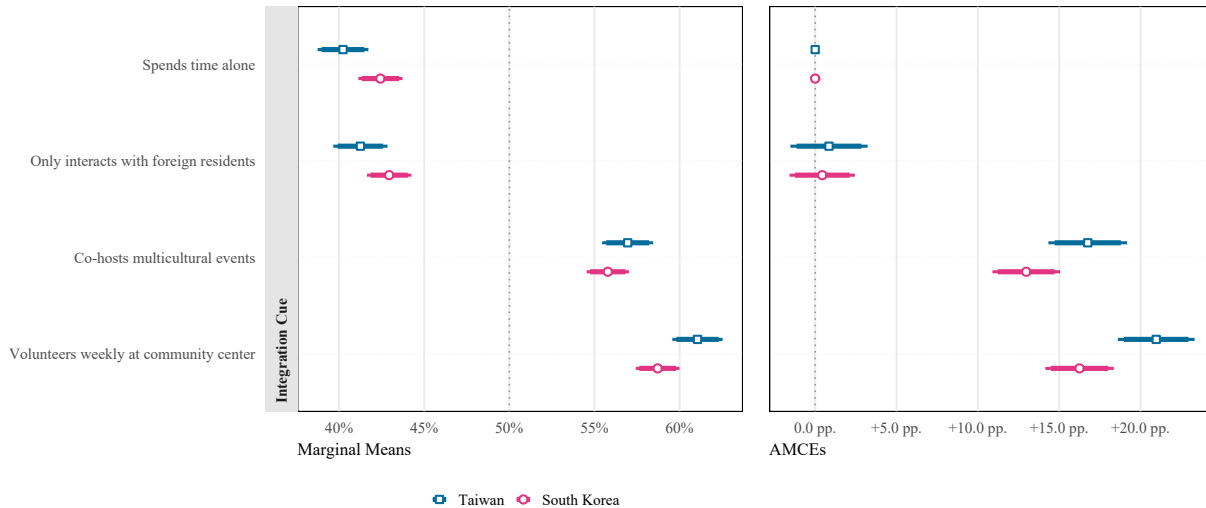


Figure 3: Marginal means and AMCEs for the effect of the integration cue attribute

Note: The analysis is based on an Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) model with clustered standard errors. Marginal means represent the expected value of the outcome variable for each attribute level, holding all other attributes at their average levels. The AMCEs estimate the average change in the outcome variable associated with a particular attribute level, relative to a reference level, averaged across the distribution of all other attributes. The error bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

These results support H_1 : immigrants who display visible, pro-integration behaviors receive a substantial “civic premium” in the eyes of native-born citizens. Notably, this premium holds in both South Korea and Taiwan, underscoring the broad appeal of behavioral integration. The stronger effects observed in Taiwan suggest that social integration cues may resonate especially in pluralistic identity environments, where boundaries of belonging are less tightly policed. We return to this pattern under H_4 , where we consider the moderating effects of differing civic legacies.

Analysis of open-text responses further corroborates these results: topic models (Appendix E of the SI) show that respondents explicitly referenced volunteering, community engagement, and related behaviors, confirming both that they understood the conjoint tasks

and that integration cues indeed shaped their evaluations of naturalization.

4.2 Integration Cues and Identity-Based Discrimination

To assess whether integration cues mitigate identity-based discrimination, we analyze support for naturalization across profiles varying in ethnic and religious background, conditional on their level of social integration (Figure 3). By including profiles with no integration cue, we establish a meaningful baseline, revealing the degree of penalty attached to ascriptive or cultural minority status in the absence of social integration cues.

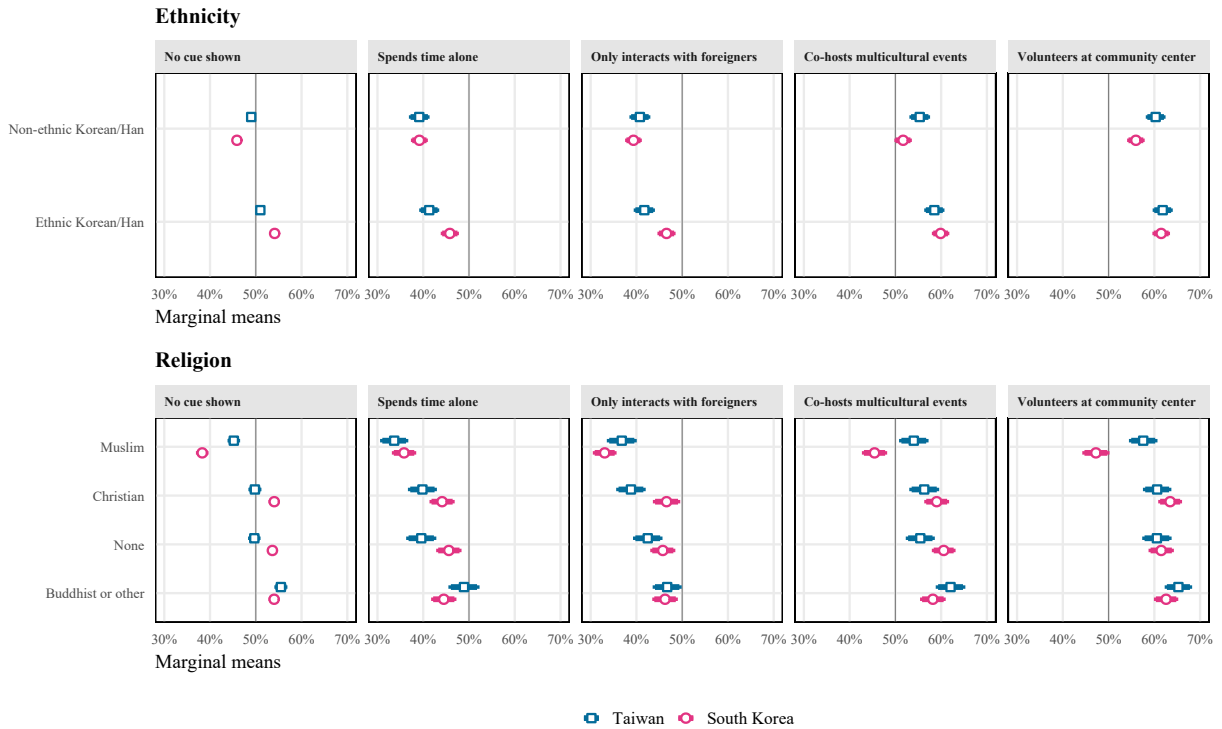


Figure 4: Marginal means for ethnicity and religion attributes conditional on integration cue exposure

Note: Each panel shows how support for naturalization varies by ethnic and religious identity under different integration cue conditions. The top panel displays effects for ethnicity (co-ethnic vs. non-co-ethnic), while the bottom panel shows effects for religion. Marginal means represent the expected probability of selection for each attribute level, holding all other attributes at their average values. Error bars represent 90 and 95 percent confidence intervals based on clustered standard errors.

The baseline penalties are clear. Across both countries, non-co-ethnic and Muslim profiles receive the lowest baseline support. Yet the penalty shrinks when these profiles signal strong integration. In Taiwan, Muslim immigrants volunteering weekly receive support levels statistically indistinguishable from Buddhist or Christian counterparts who lack integration cues. In South Korea, the ethnic penalty for non-Koreans declines by roughly 6–8 percentage points when the immigrant is described as civically engaged.

These patterns support H_2 : integration cues reduce identity-based discrimination. They function not only as positive signals but as compensatory mechanisms, allowing otherwise disadvantaged groups to overcome ascriptive or cultural biases.

However, the identity-mitigating effects of integration cues diverge by national context. In South Korea, co-ethnic immigrants (e.g., ethnic Koreans from China) enjoy a persistent advantage, even when less integrated. By contrast, non-co-ethnic immigrants remain disadvantaged relative to co-ethnics even when highly integrated, suggesting that ascriptive identity remains powerful. Notably, Muslim immigrants face a significant penalty in Korea: although integration cues elevate support, they do not fully eliminate cultural bias. Civically engaged Muslims still lag behind non-religious or Christian profiles in naturalization support, indicating that cultural threat perceptions are more resistant to behavioral mitigation in this context.

In Taiwan, however, integration cues appear to compensate for both ethnic and religious minority status fully. Muslim or non-co-ethnic immigrants who signal high civic engagement receive support levels comparable to dominant-group profiles. This suggests that Taiwanese respondents place greater emphasis on behavioral conformity than cultural origin when evaluating eligibility for citizenship. Taken together, these findings underscore that the capacity of integration cues to mitigate or eliminate identity-based discrimination is context-dependent. In Korea, ethnic and religious hierarchies appear more entrenched, whereas behavioral assimilation more effectively levels the playing field in Taiwan. We discuss the implications of these findings in the Discussion and Conclusion.

4.3 Civic Nationalist Moderation

Next, to assess whether responsiveness to integration cues varies by national identity orientation, we estimate marginal means separately for civic nationalists and all other respondents. Respondents are classified based on their answers to a multidimensional identity battery (see definitions above), distinguishing those who prioritize behavioral criteria (e.g., citizenship, language, respect for laws) from those who emphasize ascriptive traits. This subgroup analysis allows us to observe whether the civic premium for integration cues is concentrated among those predisposed to value civic alignment or whether it generalizes across identity types. Figure 4 presents the marginal support for naturalization by integration cue level, comparing civic nationalists relative to others.

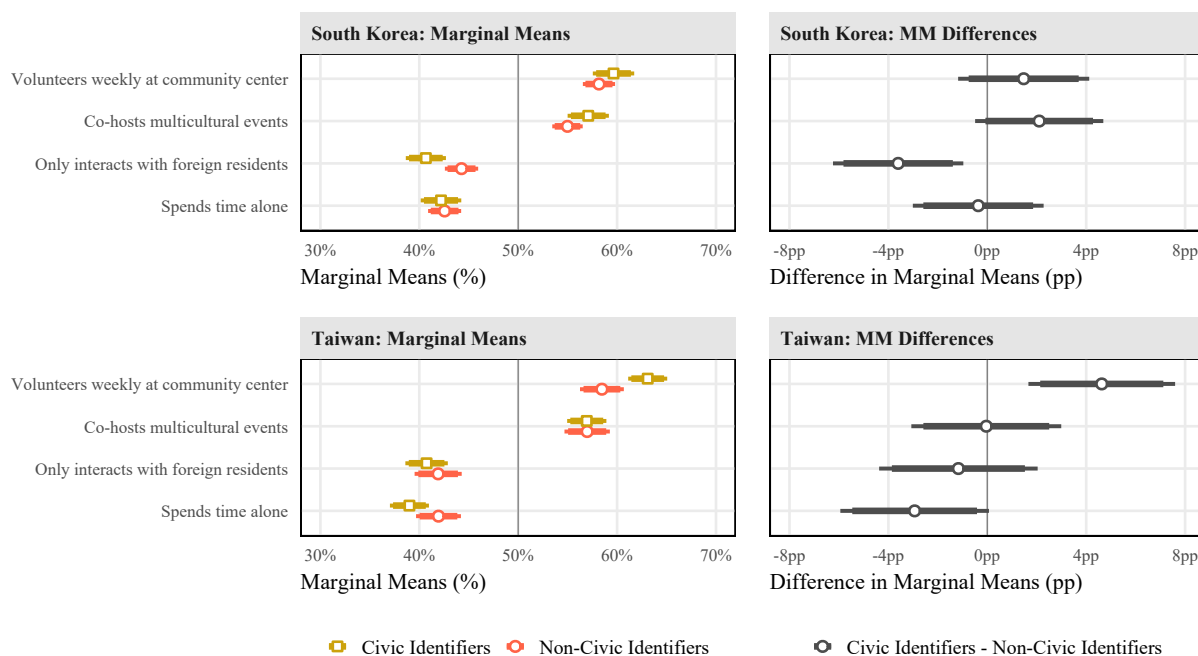


Figure 5: Integration cue effects moderated by civic versus non-civic identifiers

Note: Left panels show marginal means for integration cue levels by national identity type (civic vs. non-civic identifiers). Right panels display the difference in marginal means between the two subgroups. Error bars represent 90 and 95 percent confidence intervals based on clustered standard errors.

The findings show that civic nationalists are not uniformly more or less supportive of

immigrant naturalization. Instead, they display greater sensitivity to integration cues, adjusting their preferences based on immigrants’ observed behaviors. In South Korea, civic nationalists register notably lower support (39 percent) for immigrants who “only interact with foreign residents,” compared to 44 percent among non-civic respondents, indicating that perceived civic disengagement is more penalized by those prioritizing norm adherence. In Taiwan, no such differential is observed.

Whereas civic nationalists in Korea are more punitive toward low integrators, their Taiwanese counterparts are more positively responsive to high-integration behaviors. Specifically, support for naturalization among Taiwanese civic identifiers reaches approximately 63 percent for immigrants who volunteer weekly at a local community center, compared to 58 percent among non-civic respondents: a nearly five percentage point differential. Together, these findings offer moderate support for H4. Among civic nationalists, some behavioral integration cues exert a stronger influence on support for naturalization than others, consistent with the idea that civic inclusion is conditional on norm compliance. Yet the effect is not exclusive to this group. Even respondents who endorse more ascriptive understandings of national identity respond positively to visible signs of integration. We discuss the implications of this finding below.

4.4 Civic Legacy Moderation

We now turn to the final hypothesis, which draws on Chung’s (2020) theory of civic legacies to anticipate that integration cues will resonate more strongly in South Korea than in Taiwan. The underlying logic holds that societies with robust histories of civil society engagement around migrant rights, such as South Korea’s labor and pro-democracy movements, will be more receptive to signals of social integration. In contrast, where civic infrastructures have historically neglected immigration, such as Taiwan, citizens should exhibit weaker responses to such cues.

Across the analysis presented above, however, we find the opposite pattern. In every

primary comparison, Taiwanese respondents exhibit greater responsiveness to integration cues relative to their Korean counterparts. The marginal increase in naturalization support between low- and high-integration profiles reaches nearly 19 percentage points in Taiwan, compared to roughly 11 points in South Korea (Figure 2). Identity-based penalties tied to ethnicity and religion are also more readily neutralized by social integration cues in Taiwan. Muslim immigrants who volunteer or co-host events achieve nearly parity in Taiwanese ratings; in Korea, they remain penalized even when integration is high (Figure 3).

To assess whether such legacies could be exogenously activated, we also introduced the civic framing vignette in the experimental design, as noted above. A random subset of respondents received a message intended to mimic the elite framing that an active civil society might generate. If civic legacies are historical and cognitively salient, this message might reinforce or activate stronger responses to integration cues, particularly in Korea.

However, as reported in Appendix D, we observe no statistically significant effect of the civic-framing treatment. Integration cue responsiveness does not increase among those exposed to the prime, in either country. This null result invites two interpretations. First, the treatment itself may have been too weak or cognitively distant to generate additional effects. Assuming this is not the driver of our findings, we suspect that, second, the mechanisms emphasized in Chung’s (2020) civic legacy framework, such as elite discourse, policy activism, and institutional scaffolding, may shape integration norms at the elite or organizational level in ways that do not directly translate into public opinion shifts. Our experimental results thus do not run contrary to Chung’s argument, but instead suggest that public attitudes may lag behind, or operate independently from, the elite-driven civic processes she highlights. Further research is needed to map how civic legacies filter into mass-level responsiveness to integration cues.

4.5 Additional Analysis: Immigrant Interviews

To complement the experimental findings and assess their external validity, we draw on qualitative evidence from South Korea. This analysis uses focus group transcripts from the Immigrant Incorporation in East Asian Democracies project (Chung et al. 2015), which also informs Chung (2020), a core source for our theoretical framework. While the broader study covers both South Korea and Taiwan, only the Korean transcripts are publicly available. Korea nonetheless offers a compelling case: sustained state-led promotion of a “multicultural” civic order and a relatively institutionalized civic integration agenda make it an ideal setting for examining whether the behaviors rewarded by native-born citizens in our survey also feature in migrants’ own strategies for social inclusion.

The transcripts document the perspectives of migrants from diverse backgrounds, including Burmese, Filipino, Mongolian, Vietnamese, Han Chinese, Joseonjok (ethnic Koreans holding Chinese nationality), and Hwagyo (long-term Han Chinese residents without full citizenship rights). Designed to explore political incorporation, the interviews provide rich material for assessing whether migrants themselves view civic engagement, workplace adaptation, and norm adherence as pathways to recognition and legitimacy.

This qualitative analysis serves a corroborative function. Our conjoint experiment shows that native-born citizens in both Korea and Taiwan grant higher naturalization support to immigrants who demonstrate behavioral integration – volunteering, civic participation, or other visible commitments to shared norms. The question here is whether immigrants themselves view such behaviors as instrumental to achieving social acceptance and inclusion. The interviews suggest they do, though their interpretations and emphases demonstrate nuances in their understanding of social life as a migrant in South Korea.

Across these groups, three patterns recur: migrants describe adapting to workplace norms as a way to earn trust and legitimacy, engaging with organizations as a channel for civic and political participation, and selectively adopting dominant norms about legality and deservingness. Each of these strategies aligns, in different ways, with the integration cues

that our conjoint experiment shows native-born citizens respond positively to.

Workplaces emerge as a key arena for signaling such behaviors. Migrants repeatedly frame norm conformity, such as punctuality, teamwork, and language learning, as central to earning acceptance from colleagues. A Filipino participant explained, “They [Filipinos] know how to adjust. That is why they choose to hire Filipinos here because they work hard and know how to adjust” [...], continuing, “Filipinos who have stayed here for ten years can speak the language fluently and they know the culture” (71110F). Another added, “You need to prove it to them first. If you prove that you are better than them, then they will recognize you” (71110F). A Vietnamese respondent highlighted the sense of equality that can emerge: “In my factory, there are only Vietnamese and Korean workers. The daily life is the same for all of us” (5302010D). A Mongolian participant went further: “Koreans are like family when we work together” (Mongolian group). These reflections underscore how workplace adaptation is not just a matter of economic necessity, but a visible route to social inclusion. At the same time, some participants noted limits: workplace respect does not always translate into broader societal acceptance, and hierarchical work norms may reinforce distance rather than dissolve it.

Migrants also describe engaging in civic and community life in ways that they themselves link to belonging. A Filipino organizer explained, “As part of our mission and vision we plan community improvement projects every year... we also provided scholarships to fifty students” (71110F), while another emphasized, “If there are issues, we organize forums” (71110F). Joseonjok respondents described voluntary work that brings visibility: “We do voluntary work as well. Like picking up cigarette butts and trash from the streets.” (61210B). Burmese participants emphasized collective advocacy: “We hold meetings with Korean NGOs... we hold demonstrations and attend international conferences on Burmese democracy” (70710A). These examples illustrate that many migrants consciously adopt forms of civic engagement that echo the integration cues rewarded by Korean citizens in our survey, often with the expectation of recognition, legitimacy, or belonging.

Yet not all participants frame behaviors in these terms. Some stressed legality as the decisive criterion: “As long as you’re not legal then you can’t ask for the same benefits as a legal worker” (71110F). Others voiced resignation about exclusion despite deep roots: one Hwagyo participant remarked, “We are integrated, but Korean society does not accept us” (63010B). Such statements highlight that civic participation and norm conformity do not guarantee acceptance, and that migrants’ orientations toward these strategies vary.

Overall, the Korean interviews suggest that many migrants consciously adopt behaviors consistent with the civic fairness principle identified in our experiments, often linking them to feelings of trust, respect, or belonging. From workplace adaptation and community projects to political advocacy and voluntary work, these strategies mirror the integration cues rewarded by native-born citizens in our conjoint experiment. At the same time, the ambivalence expressed by some participants underscores that civic-oriented behaviors can signal inclusion without fully ensuring it. This qualification is important: the alignment between our survey findings and migrants’ perspectives is real, but partial and contingent.

5 Conclusion and Discussion

This study examined whether social integration cues shape public support for immigrant naturalization in Taiwan and South Korea: two non-Western democracies whose ethno-national legacies and recent demographic changes present a critical test for theories of immigrant incorporation. Using population-representative conjoint survey experiments, we evaluated four hypotheses derived from research on civic fairness, cultural threat, national identity, and civic legacies, supplemented with qualitative evidence from migrant interviews in South Korea.

Across both cases, the results show that visible participation in the civic life of the host society, such as volunteering or co-hosting community events, substantially increases support for naturalization. These effects, ranging from 11 to 19 percentage points, extend the civic

fairness logic identified in Western democracies (Levy and Wright 2020) to newer democratic contexts, suggesting that civic engagement serves as a persuasive heuristic even in societies with limited immigration histories and strong ethno-nationalist traditions.

The findings confirm that norms-conforming civic behavior can reduce exclusionary preferences, but the extent of this mitigation depends on both immigrant profile and national setting. In Taiwan, civic participation largely neutralizes identity-based penalties toward culturally distant immigrants, while in South Korea residual bias persists, particularly toward Muslim immigrants. This persistence is consistent with scholarship noting the contested role of religion in South Korea’s public sphere and the dominance of Protestant organizations in shaping civic norms (Kang 2010; Han and Park 2017). These patterns mirror observations in Western Europe (Adida, Laitin, and Valfort 2017) yet underscore the continued salience of cultural threat narratives and social hierarchies in at least the South Korean context (Seol and Skrentny 2009; Denney and Green 2021).

Identity orientations further shape responsiveness. In both settings, respondents with civic definitions of national belonging are more sensitive to integration behavior, rewarding high engagement or, in South Korea’s case, penalizing disengagement. That even respondents with more ascriptive national identities respond positively to civic participation aligns with arguments that civic fairness reflects a broadly resonant evaluative logic grounded in democratic norms of visible participation and rule-following (Pehrson, Brown, and Zagefka 2009; Reeskens and Hooghe 2010). The effect thus appears not confined to those with explicitly civic-nationalist orientations.

Institutional context also matters, but not as predicted by the civic legacy perspective. Prior work (Chung 2020) suggested that South Korea’s dense civil society infrastructure and sustained pro-immigrant advocacy would heighten the salience of integration cues, while Taiwan’s more fragmented civic environment would dampen their influence. The evidence points in the opposite direction: cue effects are consistently larger in Taiwan. This divergence from expectations rooted in associational density and democratic responsiveness (Putnam,

Leonardi, and Nanetti 1993; Paxton 2002) suggests that civic legacies do not simply amplify responsiveness; where integration behaviors are less institutionally normalized, they may instead stand out more sharply and have greater persuasive force.

The supplementary analysis of migrant interviews in South Korea reinforces these patterns. Migrants emphasize civic behaviors (e.g., volunteering, workplace adaptation) as essential to gaining recognition and navigating the boundaries of membership. That these lived experiences mirror the behaviors rewarded in our conjoint experiment strengthens the external validity of our findings and demonstrates that civic fairness has resonance in everyday life.

Our comparative results also nuance expectations about the relationship between democracy and civic nationalism (Snyder 1993; Nodia 1994; Shulman 2004; Mansfield and Snyder 2005; Banting et al. 2019). South Korea and Taiwan democratized in the late 1980s, with South Korea holding its first free national election (1987) a few years before Taiwan (1992). And yet, our results indicate substantially more open attitudes towards immigrants in Taiwan. For historically contingent reasons, political actors in Taiwan’s democratization process were incentivized to de-emphasize the ethnic component of Taiwanese identity. This may have paved the way for the stronger integration cue effects and the weaker ethnic penalties we discern in Taiwan.

Overall, the results presented in this paper extend immigration attitude research in three directions. First, they shift the focus from admission and residency (Hainmueller and Hopkins 2015; Bansak, Hainmueller, and Hangartner 2016) to naturalization, where public preferences directly intersect with state definitions of political membership (Bloemraad 2018; Peters, Vink, and Schmeets 2018). Second, they broaden the geographic scope of experimental work on behavioral cues, demonstrating that the mechanism operates in Asian democracies but manifests differently depending on cultural threat perceptions, identity hierarchies, and institutional configurations (Kustov 2025; Sniderman et al. 2004). Third, they qualify linear accounts of civic legacy effects and democratization, showing that institutional histories

shape cue interpretation in ways contingent on their visibility and normative distinctiveness. More important for shaping the outcomes appear to be the relative salience of ethno-national legacies.

The broader implications reach beyond Korea and Taiwan. In historically ethno-nationalist societies undergoing demographic change, visible civic engagement can offer a politically resonant route to public acceptance. Yet these cues work within the constraints of existing identity hierarchies and cannot fully override deep-seated ethnoreligious boundaries. Policy strategies that create visible, accessible opportunities for immigrant participation may therefore foster greater support for naturalization, but their success will depend on how such behaviors intersect with prevailing narratives of national belonging and the broader symbolic boundaries of the polity.

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Ethics Statement

This research was conducted in accordance with ethical guidelines approved by the University of Vienna Ethics Committee under decision numbers 00654 and 00997.

Data Availability Statement

Replication data supporting the findings of this study are available in a trusted repository. A private access link will be provided to reviewers upon request. The data will be made publicly available upon publication.

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Supplementary Information for “Cues of Commitment:
Integration and Naturalization Support in Taiwan and
South Korea”

Appendix A Additional survey information

From January to June 2024, we recruited nationally representative samples of native-born adults (18+) in South Korea and Taiwan using Qualtrics’ managed online panel service. Respondents were screened to ensure citizenship and were stratified by sex, age, and geographic region to reflect the most recent census distributions in each country. To enhance data quality, we implemented multiple safeguards during survey administration. These included: (1) Qualtrics’ proprietary fraud detection and security protocols (e.g., bot detection, IP verification, speed checks); (2) embedded attention checks and manipulation validation items designed by the research team; and (3) a thorough manual review of completion metadata in collaboration with the Qualtrics project manager. Responses that failed these checks were flagged and replaced before the dataset was finalized.

After applying these quality control protocols, our final sample consists of 2,005 respondents in South Korea and 2,014 in Taiwan. We are confident that these samples provide a high-quality approximation of the broader national populations. Tables A.1 and A.2 summarize the demographic distributions in each country.

Variable	Count	Proportion
Age		
≤25	240	12%
26-35	336	17%
36-45	402	20%
46-55	433	22%
>55	595	30%
Gender		
Male	1015	51%
Female	991	49%
Highest Level of Education		
No University	382	19%
University (including technical colleges)	1624	81%
Location		
Seoul	203	20%
Busan	71	7%
Daegu	49	5%
Incheon	57	6%
Gwangju	28	3%
Daejeon	29	3%
Ulsan	22	2%
Sejong	8	1%
Gyeonggi Province	238	24%
Gangwon Province	31	3%
North Chungcheong Province	31	3%
South Chungcheong Province	35	4%
North Jeolla Province	37	4%
South Jeolla Province	38	4%
North Gyeongsang Province	54	5%
South Gyeongsang Province	65	7%
Jeju	12	1%

Table A.1: Summary Counts and Proportions: South Korea

Variable	Count	Proportion
Age		
≤25	260	13%
26-35	479	23%
36-45	580	28%
46-55	404	20%
>55	327	16%
Gender		
Male	1088	53%
Female	962	47%
Highest Level of Education		
< 16 years of formal schooling	544	27%
16 years of formal schooling or more	1506	73%
Region		
New Taipei City	461	22%
Taipei City	353	17%
Taichung City	255	12%
Kaohsiung City	242	12%
Taoyuan City	211	10%
Tainan City	177	9%
Changhua County	63	3%
Hsinchu City	39	2%
Hsinchu County	37	2%
Pingtung County	33	2%
Yunlin County	31	2%
Keelung City	27	1%
Chiayi City	23	1%
Miaoli County	23	1%
Chiayi County	19	1%
Yilan County	17	1%
Nantou County	16	1%
Hualien County	10	<1%
Taitung County	8	<1%
Penghu County	3	<1%
Kinmen County	2	<1%

Table A.2: Summary Counts and Proportions: Taiwan

Appendix B Balance Checks

To verify that our randomization procedure worked correctly, we conducted balance checks examining the distribution of conjoint attribute levels across our experimental conditions. Tables B.1 and B.2 present the balance checks for the Taiwanese and South Korean samples, respectively. These tables show the proportion of each attribute level that appeared when the integration cue was shown versus when it was not shown to respondents. The balance checks reveal that randomization of both the conjoint attribute levels and the social integration cue was successful across both samples.

	Integration Cue	
	Shown	Not Shown
Age		
27	24.8%	25.1%
35	24.8%	24.9%
47	25.9%	23.9%
58	25.9%	24.8%
Ethnicity		
Han	24.8%	24.7%
Non-Han	25.9%	24.7%
Gender		
Female	25.4%	25%
Male	25.3%	24.3%
Language		
Can converse in Mandarin without problems	25.5%	24.3%
Speaks broken Mandarin	25.7%	25.3%
Can speak Mandarin fluently	24.9%	24.5%
Married	25.7%	24.7%
Married		
Single	25.6%	24.3%
Married with children	24.7%	25.1%
Company employee	25%	25%
Occupation		
Unemployed	24.9%	24.9%
Agricultural work	25.1%	24.5%
Computer engineer	26.4%	24.4%
China	24.9%	24%
Origin		
South Korea	26.1%	24.9%
Indonesia	24.6%	25.6%
USA	25.7%	24.4%
Philippines	25.5%	24.5%
Prior Visits		
Visited with a short-term work visa	24.4%	25%
Visited Taiwan once with friends	26.1%	24.8%
Overstayed previously	25.6%	24.3%
Religion		
Buddhist, Taoist, or other folk religions	26.3%	23.4%
Muslim	24.7%	26.4%
Christian	25.7%	25%
No religious belief	24.7%	23.9%
Residence Length		
5 years	25.2%	25%
8 years	25.8%	24.6%
12 years	25.1%	24.5%
Work History		
Has worked in Taiwan	24.1%	26%
Has worked in home country	25.7%	24.1%
No work experience	26.2%	24%

Table B.1: Balance table for Taiwanese sample

Note: Proportions show the distribution of attribute levels across integration cue conditions. Balance indicates whether randomization was successful across experimental conditions.

	Integration Cue	
	Shown	Not Shown
Age		
47	24.7%	24.9%
58	24.9%	24.4%
27	24.7%	25.2%
36	24.6%	24.4%
Ethnicity		
Non-ethnic Korean	24.7%	24.9%
Ethnic Korean	24.7%	24.5%
Gender		
Male	24.7%	24.3%
Female	24.8%	25.2%
Language		
Can converse in Korean	25%	23.8%
Can speak a little Korean	25%	24.3%
Can't speak Korean	25.1%	24.6%
Can speak Korean fluently	23.8%	26.1%
Married		
Single	25.1%	25.6%
Married with children	24.5%	24.2%
Married	24.7%	24.3%
Occupation		
Computer Programmer	25.2%	24.4%
Farmer	24.6%	25.7%
Unemployed	24.9%	23.9%
Office Worker	24.3%	24.8%
Origin		
Indonesia	23.7%	25.9%
Brazil	25.5%	23.8%
USA	24.6%	24.3%
China	25.2%	24.9%
Prior Visits		
Previously overstayed visa	24.7%	25.1%
Visited with a short-term work visa	24.8%	24.4%
Visited Korea once	24.7%	24.7%
Religion		
Muslim	24.5%	25.3%
Buddhist	25.6%	24%
Christian	25%	25%
None	23.9%	24.5%
Residence Length		
7 years	24.1%	24.2%
12 years	25.5%	24.3%
2 years	24.6%	25.6%
Work History		
Has work experience in home country	24.7%	24.3%
No prior work history	24.4%	25%
Has work experience in Korea	25.1%	24.8%

Table B.2: Balance table for South Korean sample

Note: Proportions show the distribution of attribute levels across integration cue conditions. Balance indicates whether randomization was successful across experimental conditions.

Appendix C Pre-Registration Information

This study was preregistered prior to data collection on the *Open Science Framework (OSF)*.¹

Research Questions

The study examines public attitudes toward immigrant integration in South Korea, Japan, and Taiwan. Specifically:

1. Do differences in civic legacies and civil society movements affect support for immigrant integration?
2. Do integration cues motivate support for naturalization and decrease identity-based discrimination?
3. Do integration cues sway civic nationalists in support of integration?

Hypotheses

H_1 : Integration cues motivate support for naturalization.

H_2 : Integration cues decrease identity-based discrimination (by origin and ethnicity).

H_3 : Civic legacies moderate the effects of integration cues on identity-based discrimination.

H_4 : Civic nationalist beliefs moderate the effects of integration cues.

Experimental Design

- **Method:** Choice-based conjoint survey experiments.
- **Cases:** South Korea, Japan, and Taiwan.
- **Samples:** Representative online panels of native-born adults.

¹DOI to pre-registered on the Open Science Framework (OSF) to be provided at time of publication.

- **Profiles:** Each respondent evaluated ten randomized choice tasks between two hypothetical immigrants. Profiles varied on eleven attributes (demographic, socio-economic, and integration-related).
- **Key attributes of interest:**
 - Origin and ethnicity (identity markers)
 - Social integration cue (randomized)
 - Civil society message framing (randomized)

Outcomes

- **Primary dependent variable:** Choice between two immigrant profiles for naturalization.
- **Secondary measures:** 7-point preference scale; open-ended justification after the fourth task.

Analysis Plan

- Estimation of average marginal component effects (AMCEs) and marginal means (MMs).
- Statistical significance threshold: $p < 0.05$.
- Pre-specified robustness checks: scaled preference questions; textual justification coding.
- Planned subgroup analyses: interaction of integration cues with identity attributes, civic legacy framing, and civic nationalist orientation (measured following Bonikowski & DiMaggio 2016; Bonikowski et al. 2021).

C.1 Deviations from Pre-Registration

Two deviations from the preregistered design merit mention.

Operationalization of Cultural Proximity. In the preregistration, cultural proximity/distance was operationalized using immigrants’ country of *origin*. Following feedback received during presentation of preliminary results, we revised this operationalization to focus on *religion* instead. This change reflects the importance of religious identity as a salient marker of cultural distance in both South Korea and Taiwan. Religion provides a more theoretically precise and contextually meaningful dimension than country of origin for capturing variation in perceived cultural proximity.²

Case Selection. The preregistration specified three country cases: South Korea, Taiwan, and Japan. In the final study, Japan was dropped. This adjustment was primarily pragmatic, reflecting research funding priorities. Substantively, Japan was the intermediate case between South Korea and Taiwan in terms of civil society legacies and public discourse on immigrant incorporation. Given the stronger theoretical contrasts between South Korea and Taiwan, we judged that retaining these two cases would generate the most analytical leverage. The manuscript details how these contrasts allow us to assess the scope conditions of integration cue effects and civic legacy arguments in East Asia.

²The specific source of this feedback is temporarily redacted to preserve author anonymization until publication.

Appendix D Additional Conjoint Analysis

In this appendix we provide supplementary analyses that extend the main results presented in the manuscript. These analyses include: (i) full models with all attribute levels, (ii) robustness checks based on the rating outcome measure, and (iii) exploratory models incorporating the civil society framing treatment. The intention is not to provide a full interpretation of each result here, but rather to document these additional analyses for transparency and completeness.

Full Models

Figures C.1 and C.2 present the full benchmark OLS models for South Korea and Taiwan, respectively. These models display marginal means for all immigrant attribute levels, both with and without the social integration cue. While the main text focuses on key quantities of interest (integration cues, ethnicity, and religion), the figures here provide a complete view of the baseline estimates across all randomized attributes.

Ratings-Based Measure

Figures C.3 and C.4 replicate the conjoint analysis using the seven-point rating-based measure rather than the forced-choice outcome. This robustness check demonstrates that the substantive findings are not an artifact of the forced-choice design. The vertical lines in these figures indicate the median rating points. The pattern of results closely mirrors the main analyses: integration cues substantially increase support for immigrant naturalization, and the moderation by ethnic and religious background is preserved.

Civil Society Framing Treatment

Finally, Figures C.5 and C.6 display the exploratory analyses that included the civil society (CS) framing prime. Respondents were randomly assigned to receive (or not receive) the

following introductory statement prior to the conjoint tasks:

This policy initiative is the result of a collaboration between the government, NGOs, religious groups, and local community leaders. Their joint efforts aim to construct a more balanced and inclusive immigration system for newcomers.

Overall, the findings show that the civil society framing prime did not meaningfully alter respondents' evaluations. While one can observe small fluctuations across some attribute levels, these appear closer to random variation than to systematic treatment effects. In both South Korea and Taiwan, the integration cue patterns and all other attribute values remain essentially unchanged by the presence of the prime, consistent with the manuscript discussion.

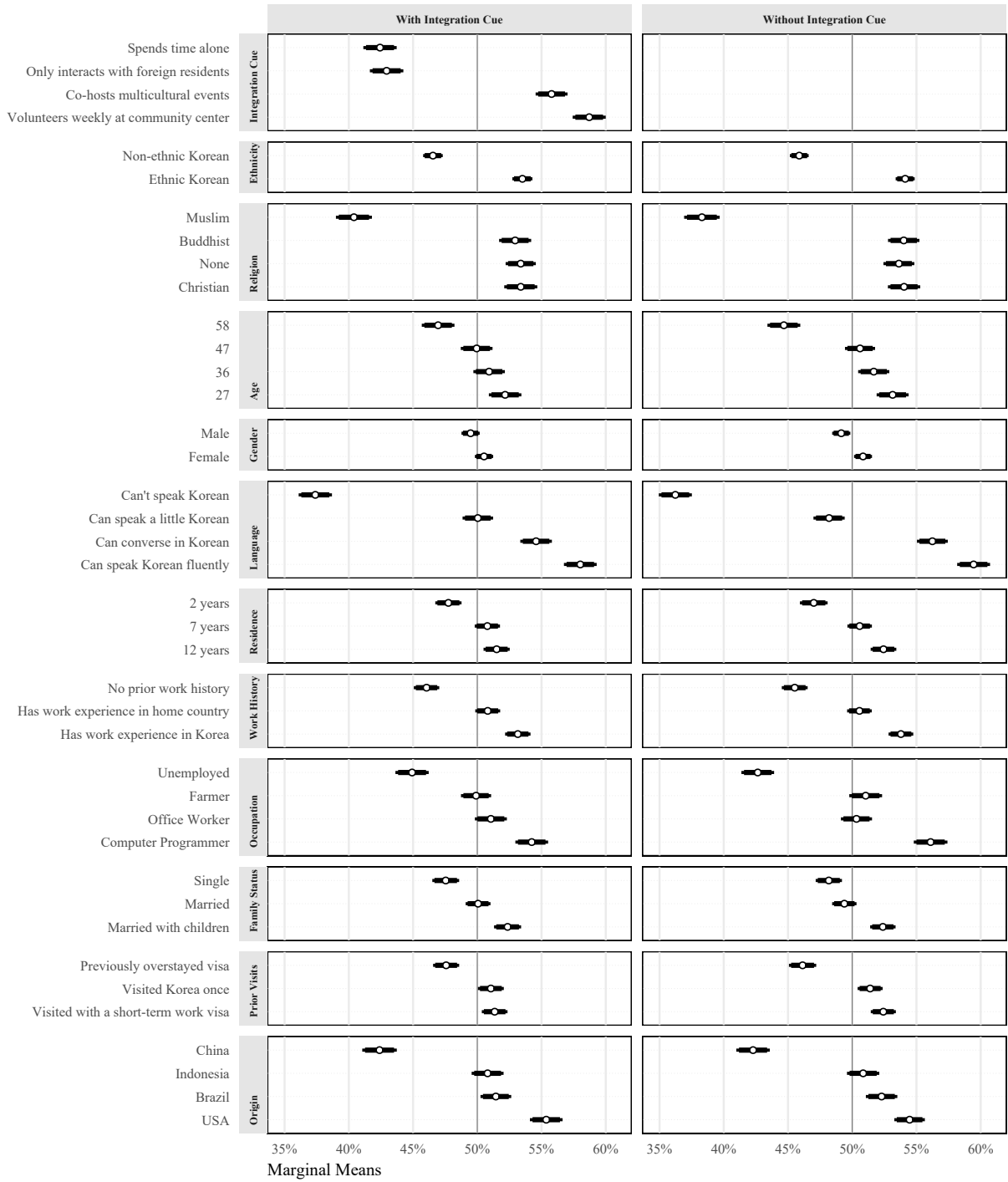


Figure D.1: Marginal means of all immigrant attribute levels with and without the integration cue: South Korea.

Note: Based on the benchmark OLS model with clustered standard errors. The marginal means show the mean outcome of each attribute level, averaged across all others. Error bars indicate 90% and 95% confidence intervals.

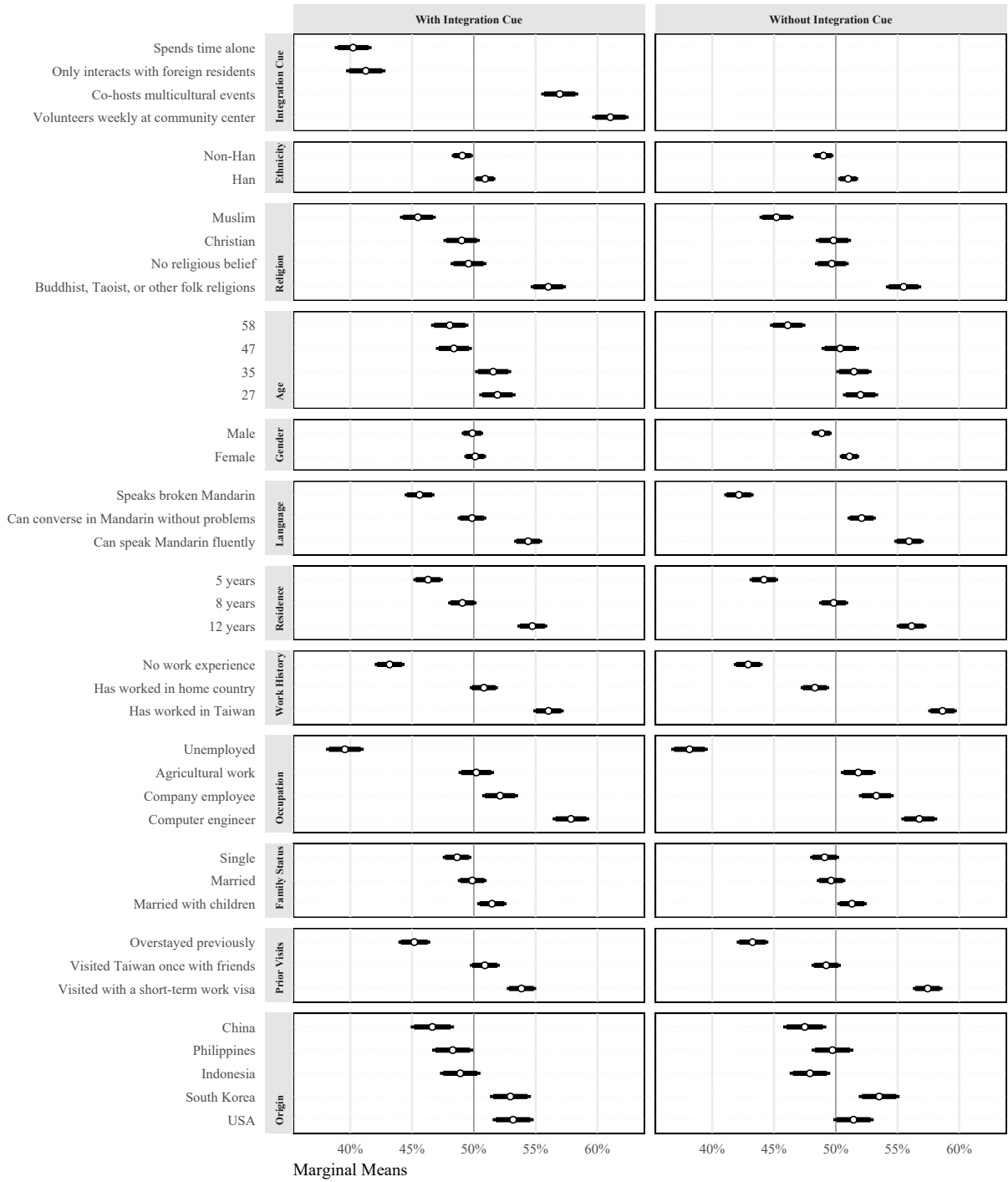


Figure D.2: Marginal means of all immigrant attribute levels with and without the integration cue: Taiwan.

Note: Based on the benchmark OLS model with clustered standard errors. The marginal means show the mean outcome of each attribute level, averaged across all others. Error bars indicate 90% and 95% confidence intervals.

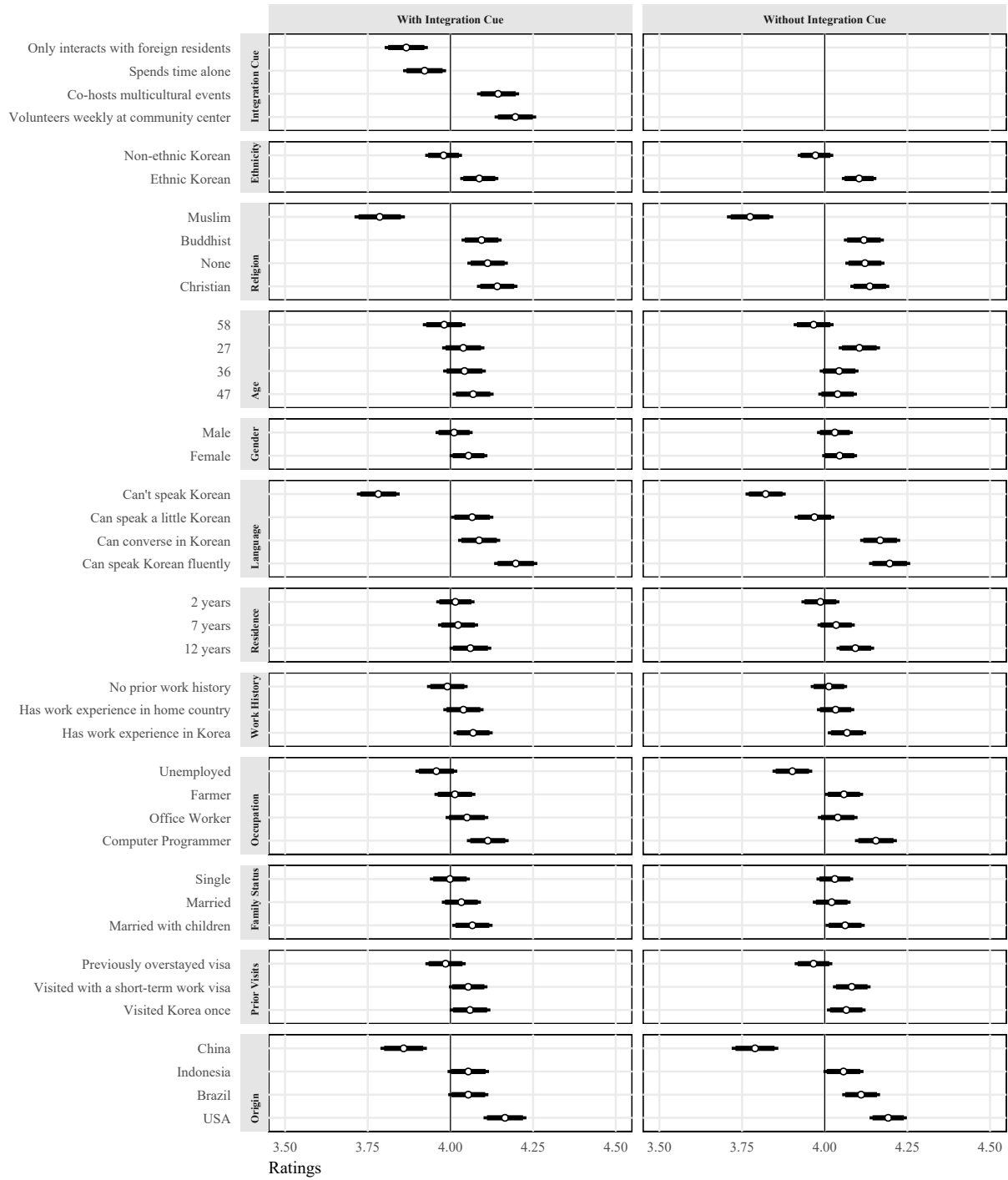


Figure D.3: Ratings-based marginal means of all immigrant attribute levels with and without the integration cue: South Korea.

Note: The vertical lines represent median points on the seven-point scale. Results reproduce the main forced-choice findings using an alternative outcome measure. Error bars indicate 90% and 95% confidence intervals.

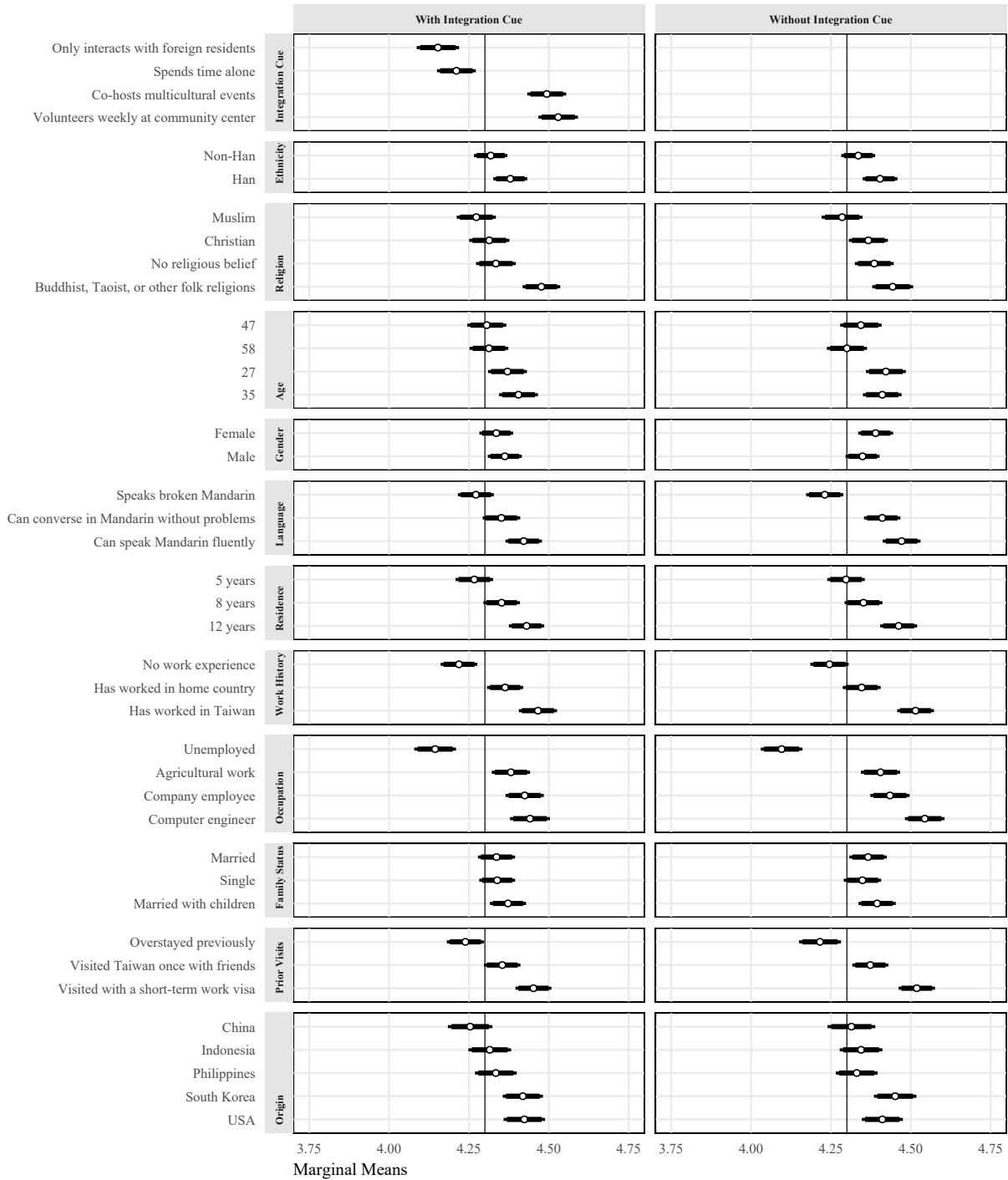


Figure D.4: Ratings-based marginal means of all immigrant attribute levels with and without the integration cue: Taiwan.

Note: The vertical lines represent median points on the seven-point scale. Results reproduce the main forced-choice findings using an alternative outcome measure. Error bars indicate 90% and 95% confidence intervals.

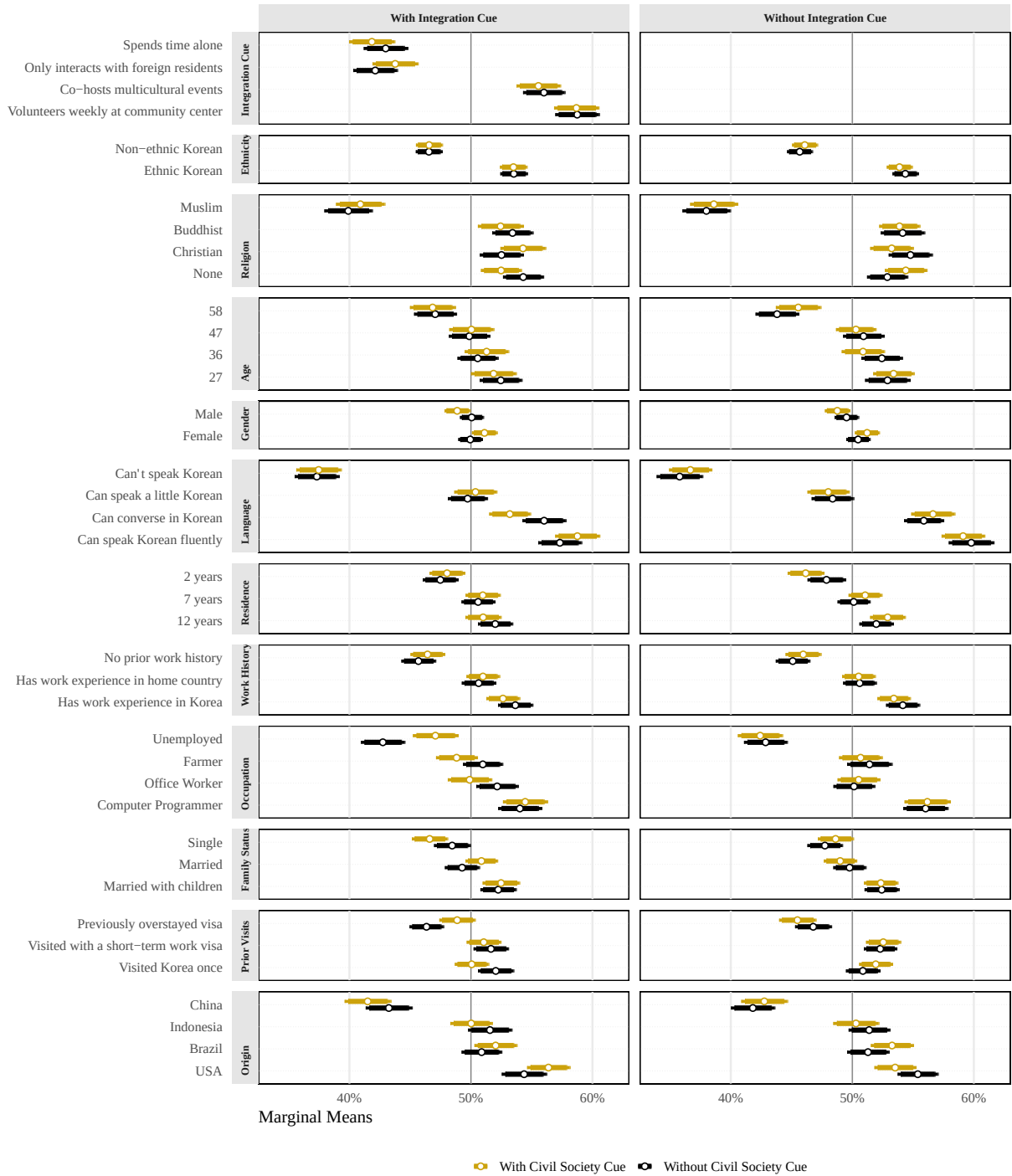


Figure D.5: Marginal means of all immigrant attribute levels with and without the integration cue, by civil society framing treatment: South Korea.

Note: Estimates are based on the benchmark OLS model with clustered standard errors. The marginal means show the average outcome for each attribute level, separately for respondents exposed to the civil society framing prime and those in the control group. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals.

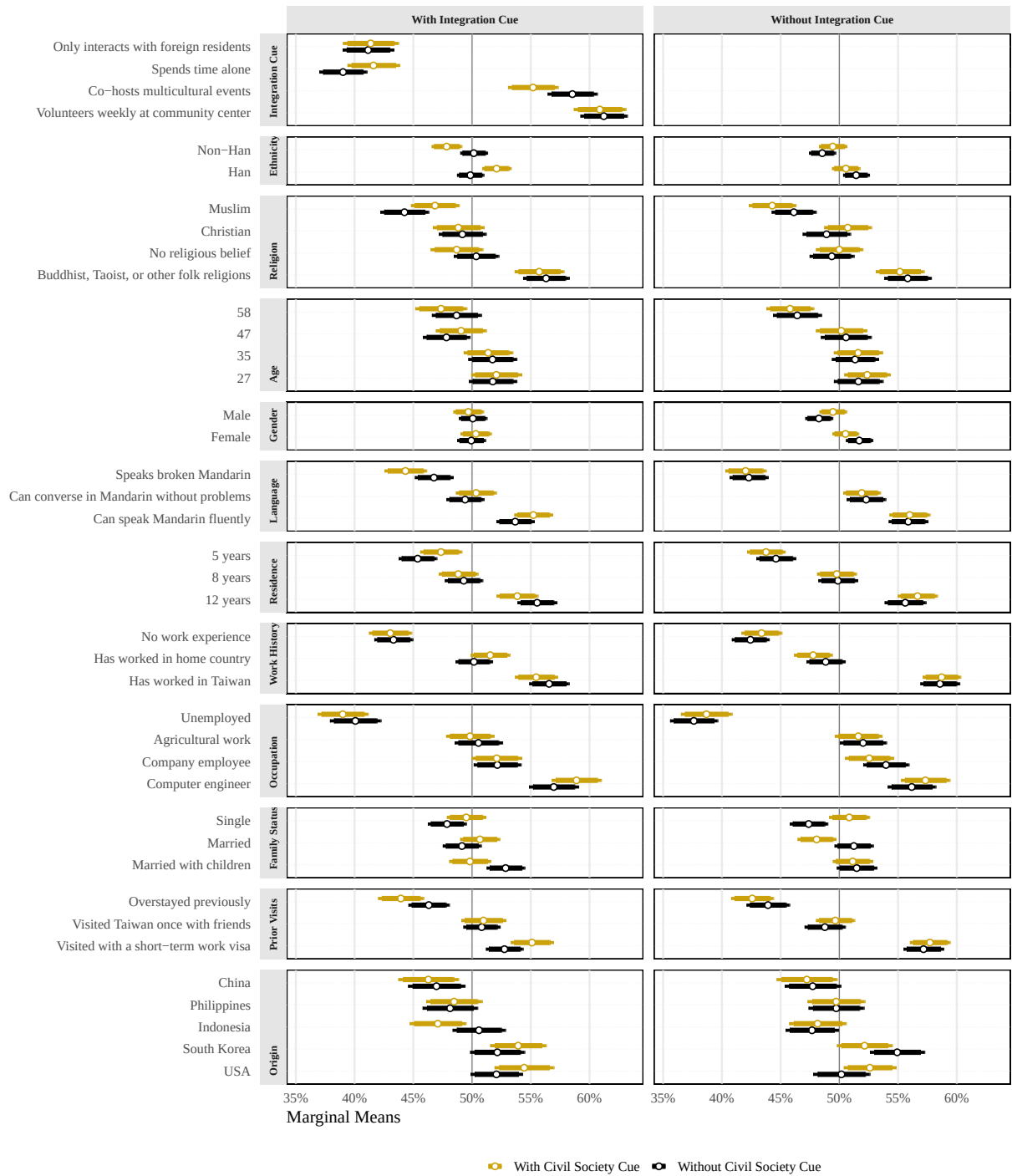


Figure D.6: Marginal means of all immigrant attribute levels with and without the integration cue, by civil society framing treatment: Taiwan.

Note: Estimates are based on the benchmark OLS model with clustered standard errors. The marginal means show the average outcome for each attribute level, separately for respondents exposed to the civil society framing prime and those in the control group. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals.

Appendix E Open-Text Topic Models

To validate that respondents noticed and processed the integration cues in our conjoint experiment, we conducted topic modeling analysis on open-text manipulation check responses. After completing the conjoint tasks, respondents were asked to describe what they noticed about the immigrant profiles or what stood out to them. We focus on open-text immediately following conjoint tasks where respondents who were shown integration cues to determine whether these experimental manipulations about social integration were salient and understood as intended.

For Taiwan, we analyzed 959 open-text responses from respondents who saw integration cues during the conjoint tasks. Using Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA) topic modeling with Chinese text processing through the `quanteda` package, we identified eight distinct topics. For South Korea, we analyzed 837 responses with integration cues, yielding four distinct topics through Korean text processing. The number of topics was determined through coherence score analysis, balancing model fit with interpretability.

The topic modeling reveals strong evidence that integration cues were successfully detected and processed by respondents in both countries. In Taiwan (Table E.1), multiple topics directly relate to social integration behaviors. **Topic 6** focuses explicitly on acceptance and multiculturalism, featuring terms like "acceptance," "diverse," "multicultural," and "society," which directly correspond to our integration cue manipulations about community engagement and multicultural events. **Topic 8** captures political participation and local involvement with terms including "participation," "activities," "political participation," and "local," closely aligning with our community volunteering cues.

Additional Taiwan topics show broader attention to integration-relevant characteristics. **Topic 1** emphasizes legal citizenship and language requirements, **Topic 3** focuses on national identity and respect for traditions, and **Topic 5** highlights democratic values and birth criteria—all factors that interact with social integration behaviors in immigrant acceptance.

In South Korea (Table E.2), the four topics demonstrate even clearer attention to integration cues. **Topic 1** directly captures community engagement with terms like "activity," "volunteer," "volunteer activity," "help," and "with neighbors"—precisely matching our experimental manipulation about community volunteering. **Topic 2** addresses work experience and multiculturalism, including the preserved term "multicultural" and references to social interaction. **Topics 3 and 4** focus heavily on language abilities, featuring "Korean language," "speak Korean fluently," "Korean possible," and "language ability," which relates to integration through linguistic assimilation.

The Korean results particularly validate our manipulation, as **Topic 1** explicitly identifies the community volunteering integration cue, while the prominence of language-related topics suggests respondents understood that social integration involves both behavioral engagement and linguistic competence. The appearance of terms like "with neighbors" and "social" in the Korean analysis directly reflects attention to the social integration behaviors we experimentally varied.

These results provide strong evidence that our integration cue manipulations were salient and processed as intended across both countries. The topic modeling successfully identifies themes related to community participation, multicultural engagement, and social behaviors—the core elements of our experimental treatment. This validation supports the internal validity of our conjoint experiment measuring determinants of social integration preferences.

Rank	Topic 1	Topic 2	Topic 3	Topic 4	Topic 5	Topic 6	Topic 7	Topic 8
1	Taiwan	Taiwan	Identity	Residence	Taiwan	Citizens	Opposition	Politics
2	Citizens	China	Country	Time	Democracy	Our country	Communism	Participation
3	Taiwan citizens	Culture	Taiwan	Taiwan	Birth	Our citizens	Anti-communism	Activities
4	Law	Values	National identity	Comparison	System	Acceptance	Permanent	Political activities
5	Chinese	Also	Taiwan identity	Residence time	Identity	Person	Residents	Political participation
6	Status	Birthplace	Respect	Taiwan residence	Taiwan birth	Feelings	Permanent residents	Political system
7	Legal status	Cultural values	Important	Feelings	Taiwan birth	Diverse	Strong	Local
8	Fluent	Not	Tradition	Democracy	Most	Multicultural	Strong opposition	None
9	Chinese fluent	Taiwan also	Values	Intuition	Democratic system	Society	Identity	Opinion
10	Can speak	Also China	Protect	Taiwan time	Like	Han people	Communist	System

Table E.1: Top 10 Terms per Topic: Taiwan Open-Text Responses (N=959 responses, 8 topics)

Rank	Topic 1	Topic 2	Topic 3	Topic 4
1	Activity	Work in Korea	Religion	Korean language
2	Volunteer	Work	Korean	Because they can
3	Volunteer activity	Experience	Korea	Fluently
4	In Korea	Experience	Korean descent	Speak Korean fluently
5	Korean	Work experience in Korea	Just	Occupation
6	Help	Work experience	Possible	Have
7	Korea	Because have	Korean possible	Religion
8	Korean language	Multicultural	Same	In addition
9	Young	Korea	Ability	Marriage
10	With neighbors	Social	Language	Immigration

Table E.2: Top 10 Terms per Topic: South Korea (N=837 responses, 4 topics)